



“By creating an enabling regulatory framework and policy, the government is encouraging manufacturers to enhance capabilities and increase production”

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DIRECTOR & CO-FOUNDER,
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FOUNDER & CEO, GARUDA
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2018, but a lot of work was needed in terms of creating infrastructure on the part of the government and meeting compliance and standards on the part of manufacturers. “The pandemic sort of made us realise that there was a need for drones to be made a part of our daily lives urgently,” says Ankit Mehta, Co-founder & CEO of Navi Mumbai-based ideaForge Technology, India’s largest drone maker. He adds that use cases such as policing, focussed spraying (of disinfectants) and the SVAMITVA scheme for mapping land parcels during that period helped unlock the potential of civilian drones.

Agrees Agnishwar Jayaprakash, Founder & CEO of Chennai-based drone maker Garuda Aerospace. “Starting with the liberalisation of the drone rules, the government has started perceiving the segment in a much more favourable light. Earlier, people thought drones could only be used in photographing weddings and events, but now they are being extensively utilised in several multi-billion-dollar segments. For instance, drones fit well on crop sprayers, are far more efficient, cover a wider area, and are capable of saving up to 70 per cent of [the cost of] pesticides and fertilisers for farmers,” he says.

Then there’s the defence sector. ideaForge’s Mehta, who became interested in drones after watching the 26/11 attacks in Mumbai, adds, “The geopolitical situation has led to drones becoming a must-have for the defence forces.” He has a point. Drones have been used with devastating effect to strike enemy targets by the US forces in Afghanistan and intrusions into Indian territory by Pakistan-based terror groups and drug traffickers.

As a result, original equipment manufacturers have been getting type certificates for specific models from aviation regulator Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA). To date, over 7,000 unique identification numbers (UINs) and 14 type certifications have been issued for drones by the DGCA. “While overall institutional demand is yet to coalesce into something substantial, drone manufacturers are seeing healthy demand from small, niche and private players, thus moving revenues upwards,” says Akshya Singhal, Consulting Partner for the Government and Public Sector at EY India.

The government’s production-linked incentive (PLI) scheme has also helped. The total financial outlay during three years of the scheme for drones and drone components is capped at ₹120 crore, with the government having notified 23 PLI beneficiaries in the space so far, of which 12 are drone manufacturers. The combined annual sales turnover of the beneficiaries has increased 3.6 times, from ₹88 crore in FY21 to ₹319 crore in FY22.

The idea behind the scheme was to strengthen the local drone ecosystem by incentivising indigenous manufacturing. “The PLI scheme has given local manufacturers the boost and financial push required to in-